

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 4 - The Fibonacci Spiral Through the Generations

Chapter 17 - Joe and the Storm

Chapter 17: Joe and the Storm

My Father

I need to tell you about my father.

Not the facts first — though the facts matter and I will give them to you. Not the timeline, the résumé, the list of accomplishments that people read at memorials and nod at without feeling. I need to tell you about the man. The actual human being who raised me. The one who drove me to school and picked me up from practice and sat at the kitchen table explaining things I did not yet have the capacity to understand. The one who believed — with a conviction I have only begun to appreciate in the years since he left — that the world could be made better by one man holding the line.

Joe Clokey. Born November 28, 1961. Cal Poly San Luis Obispo — not film school, not business school, but horticulture. The science of growing things. He studied how things grow. I think about this constantly now, because everything he did for the rest of his life was an expression of that training: the patient, disciplined, season-dependent work of cultivating something alive.

He founded San Luis Video Publishing and produced over two hundred educational films. Two hundred. Not blockbusters. Not viral content. Educational films — the quiet, necessary work of taking knowledge and making it accessible. The kind of work that does not make you famous but makes the world slightly more intelligent, one viewer at a time. He married my mother, Joan Rock Clokey, and they had three children: Shasta, Sequoia, and me. Sage. The youngest. Named, like my siblings, for something that grows.

He was not a famous man. He was not a public figure. He did not seek attention or platform or influence for its own sake. He was a man who worked. Who showed up. Who kept his word. Who believed that the right thing, done consistently over a long enough period of time, would eventually prevail.

He was wrong about that last part. At least in the way the world measures it. But I am getting ahead of myself.

The Inheritance

When Art Clokey died on January 8, 2010, the world lost a creator. Our family lost the man who had held Gumby for sixty years. And my father inherited a mission.

Joe became president of Premavision — Clokey Productions. The studio that Art had named after universal love. The company that had never been sold, never been acquired, never been handed to a conglomerate for distribution. The thing that was still alive, still carrying the code, still encoded with *Prema*.

But alive is not the same as safe. Alive is not the same as funded. Alive is not the same as understood by an industry that had spent the years since Art's heyday consolidating into a handful of corporations that control the vast majority of children's entertainment worldwide.

My father did not inherit a business. He inherited a seed in a world of swords. And he spent the next eight years of his life — the last eight years of his life — trying to plant it in soil that refused to receive it.

The Eight Years

I am going to tell this part plainly, because it deserves plain telling. The facts are heavy enough without decoration.

Classic Media: Six Years

Joe's first major partnership was with Classic Media, later acquired by DreamWorks Classics, later absorbed into NBCUniversal. Six years. He worked with them for six years to bring Gumby back in a way that honored Art's vision. He attended meetings. He flew to offices. He pitched concepts. He waited for calls. He followed up on promises. He trusted the process, because he was a man who trusted processes — who believed that if you showed up with something real, the system would eventually recognize it.

Nothing was produced. Six years. Not a single episode. Not a single film. Not a single piece of new Gumby content. Six years of a man's life spent in the machinery of an industry that had no intention of using the machine to create anything — only to *hold* the property, to sit on the rights, to prevent anyone else from using them while deciding whether the brand could be monetized on the industry's terms.

Jim Henson Company

After Classic Media, Joe pursued the Jim Henson Company. This should have been the natural partnership — Henson's legacy of puppetry, of handmade characters, of believing that craft could carry story. Joe believed that the Henson company would understand what Gumby was. That they would see the clay, the *Prema*, the living quality of the animation, and say: *yes, this is ours too. This is the same tradition. Let us do this together.*

The Henson company was interested. But they could not find a co-production partner. In the language of the industry, this means: no one else would put up the money. No one else wanted to bet on clay animation in a world that had gone digital. No one else saw the value in a green figure from the 1950s when the market was chasing the next franchise, the next IP, the next guaranteed return on investment.

The co-production partner never materialized. The project died in development.

Amazon

Then Amazon. The new player. The disruptor. The company that was supposed to be different — that had the resources, the platform, the appetite for content that the traditional studios lacked. Joe pitched Gumby to Amazon.

It fell through. I do not know all the reasons. I was young. The details were kept from me, the way parents keep the weight of their failures from their children — not out of dishonesty, but out of love. Out of the belief that a child should not have to carry what the parent is carrying.

It fell through.

Papercutz Comics

Three issues. Papercutz published three Gumby comic books. Then cancelled the series. Three issues. After six years with Classic Media, after the Henson dead end, after Amazon fell through — three comic books, and then nothing.

Gumby Imagined

In November 2017, Joe and my mother, Joan, published *Gumby Imagined* — a beautiful book documenting the art, the history, the creative process behind Gumby. It was an act of love. It was also an act of record — a way of ensuring that the *why* behind the clay was written down, captured, preserved, in case the industry never gave the *how* a chance.

I think, looking back, that they knew. Not consciously. Not in a way they would have articulated. But somewhere in the act of writing that book — of gathering the art, telling the stories, documenting the philosophy — they were building an ark. They were putting the seed in a vessel that could survive the flood.

The book was published in November 2017. Joe died four months later.

The Weight

I want you to understand what eight years of this does to a person.

Not abstractly. Not as a business case study or a cautionary tale about the entertainment industry. Concretely. Physically. What it does to the body of a man who believes in something, who has inherited a sacred trust from his father, who wakes up every morning carrying the weight of a legacy he did not choose but cannot set down — and who is told, day after day, year after year, that the thing he is carrying has no value.

Not in those words. The industry never says *your thing has no value*. The industry says: *we're still in discussions. The timing isn't right. We need a co-production partner. Let's revisit this next quarter*. The industry says *maybe* for six years, because *maybe* costs nothing and *no* provokes a response. The industry strings you along because stringing is cheaper than deciding, and the man on the other end of the string is burning his life force waiting for a decision that was made in the first meeting and never communicated.

My father was not a naive man. He understood the industry. He had produced over two hundred films. He knew how the machine worked. But he believed — and this was his greatness and his tragedy — that the machine could be persuaded. That if you brought something real, something alive, something carrying sixty years of unbroken creative vision, the machine would see it and say yes.

The machine does not say yes to living things. The machine says yes to products. And Gumby, as long as a Clokey was holding it, was not a product. It was a living thing. It had *Prema* in its code and a man standing over it who would not let the code be stripped out. The machine could not use it on the machine's terms. So the machine said *maybe* until the man carrying it collapsed.

The Last Conversation

A few months before he died, my father said something to me.

I was fourteen years old. I did not understand what he was telling me. I have spent every year since trying to understand it.

He told me he was being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was.

Jim Henson died on May 16, 1990, at the age of fifty-three. Bacterial pneumonia. He had been in negotiations to sell the Muppets to Disney — negotiations that had dragged on, that had consumed his energy, that had placed him in the position of defending his creation's integrity against a corporation that wanted the form without the soul. Henson was exhausted. He delayed going to the hospital. He

died of something treatable because he was too worn down to take care of himself.

My father saw the parallel. He saw it clearly enough to say it out loud. He saw that the industry was doing to him what it had done to Henson — not with malice, not with a conscious plan, but through the grinding, indifferent pressure of a system that does not care whether the man on the other end of the negotiation survives. The system cares about the property. The man is incidental.

He was being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was.

He told his fourteen-year-old son this. I do not know if he told anyone else. I do not know if he meant it as a warning, a confession, a cry for help, or simply the truth spoken aloud because it needed to be spoken. I know that he said it. I know that I heard it. And I know that four months after publishing *Gumby Imagined*, my father was dead.

March 2, 2018

Joe Clokey died on March 2, 2018. Cardiac arrest. He was fifty-six years old.

Fifty-six.

Art lived to eighty-eight. Joe made it to fifty-six. The math of that — the thirty-two years stolen, the decades of life that should have been — is something I carry in my body, not my mind. My mind can process the fact. My body holds the weight of it.

He died in the middle of the fight. Not at the end — there was no end. The fight was still going. The calls were still being made. The pitches were still being prepared. He died the way soldiers die in wars that have no front line — not in a decisive battle, but in the accumulated exhaustion of a conflict that never pauses, never declares a truce, never gives the man in the field a single day when he does not have to carry the weight.

The heart gave out. That is the medical fact. Cardiac arrest. The heart — the organ that pumps the blood, that sustains the body, that keeps the man alive so the man can do the work — stopped. It could not carry the load anymore. The weight of the legacy, the weight of the industry, the weight of eight years of *maybe* from people who meant *no* — the heart held all of it until it couldn't.

I was fourteen. My brother Sequoia was older. My sister Shasta was the oldest. My mother was suddenly a widow carrying the same legacy that had killed her husband, without the partner who had been carrying it with her.

I did not understand what I had lost. Not then. At fourteen, you understand death the way you understand a foreign language — you recognize the words but the meaning has not settled into your bones yet. The meaning settles later. It settles when you are nineteen and trying to decide what to do

with your life. It settles when you are twenty-one and reading about the industry that ground your father down. It settles when you are twenty-two and writing a book about the philosophy that fueled a family for three generations, and you realize that you are writing it because the man who should have written it is not here.

What He Left

Joe Clokey left three things that matter.

He left the record. *Gumby Imagined* — the book he and Joan wrote in the last year of his life. The archive of Art's vision. The documentation of the *Prema*. The ark that survived the flood.

He left the principle. Principled love in action — eight years of fighting not for money, not for fame, not for market share, but for the soul of something he had inherited and refused to let be hollowed out. He showed what it costs to hold the line. He showed that the cost is real and the cost is everything. And he showed — by paying it — that some things are worth the cost.

And he left us. Shasta, Sequoia, and Sage. Three seeds. Named for things that grow. Raised by a man who studied horticulture and spent his life trying to cultivate something alive in an industry that only knew how to harvest.

I am the youngest. I am the one who heard the last warning. I am the one who carries the sentence — *being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was* — like a coal in my chest that will not go out.

And I am the one who is writing this. Not because I chose to. Because the seed does not choose to grow. The seed grows because growing is what seeds do. The code is in the structure. The word was spoken before I was born. The man who planted me named me Sage — a word that means wisdom, a plant that means healing, a name that carries a weight I am only beginning to understand.

For My Father

Dad.

I did not understand what you were telling me. I was fourteen and the words passed through me the way light passes through glass — I felt the warmth but did not see the shape.

I see it now.

You were telling me that the fight was killing you. That the industry you were trying to reach was unreachable. That the system was not designed to receive what you were offering, and the gap

between what you carried and what they could accept was the gap that was destroying you.

You were right. And you should not have had to carry it alone.

I cannot go back and carry it with you. I cannot take the weight off the heart that gave out. I cannot undo the six years with Classic Media or the co-production partner that never came or the Amazon deal that fell through or the three comic books that were all the world gave you for eight years of your life.

But I can grow what you planted. I can take the seed — the *Prema*, the principle, the vision of a world where creators do not have to sell their souls to reach their audience — and I can put it in new soil. Soil you never had access to. Soil that did not exist when you were alive. Technology that distributes without gatekeepers. Media that reaches without permission. A world where the sword is losing its grip and the seed is finding cracks in the concrete that were not there before.

The fight that killed you was the right fight. The principle you held was the right principle. The love you carried — principled, fierce, costly, uncompromising — was the real thing. The green flame that burned in Art and passed to you is burning still. In me. In this work. In the book you are reading now.

I will not sell.

I will not stop.

I will grow what you planted, and I will build it so deep into the structure that no one can strip it out without destroying the whole thing.

For you. For Art. For *Prema*.

For the man who studied horticulture and spent his life growing something the world was not ready to receive.

The world is getting ready now.

Joe Clokey. November 28, 1961 — March 2, 2018.

Horticulturist. Filmmaker. Father. Steward.

He held the line. The line held him until it couldn't.

The seeds he planted are growing.